WARSAW, POLAND

National Museum in Warsaw: Masterpieces

Battles and allegories meet sellers, mourners and figures waiting without an audience.



Matejko's battlefield demands that attention move among competing actions. His seated Stańczyk does the opposite: the jester is set apart while festivity continues elsewhere. Both works make a historical subject depend on how people are distributed across a picture. The crowd and the solitary figure offer different ways of assigning responsibility and significance.

The selection widens that question through street sellers, bereaved householders, exiles and working artists. A person need not occupy an official historical role to deserve sustained attention. Compare what each setting permits a figure to do, what it makes visible about that person's circumstances, and what remains unavailable despite the apparent intimacy of the view.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/national-museum-warsaw

The selection · 20

1. The Battle of Grunwald
   Jan Matejko · 1878
2. Stańczyk during a Ball at the Court of Queen Bona
   Jan Matejko · 1862
3. Equestrian Portrait of Stanisław Kostka Potocki
   Jacques-Louis David · 1781
4. Four
   Józef Chełmoński · 1880
5. Partridges in the Snow
   Józef Chełmoński · 1891
6. Jewish Woman with Oranges
   Aleksander Gierymski · c. 1880 - 1881
7. Peasant Coffin
   Aleksander Gierymski · 1894
8. In the Orangery
   Olga Boznańska · 1890
9. Portrait of a Black Woman
   Anna Bilińska · 1884
10. Unfinished Self-Portrait
    Anna Bilińska · 1892
11. Polish Hamlet: Portrait of Aleksander Wielopolski
    Jacek Malczewski · 1903
12. Foot Washing: A Siberian Scene
    Jacek Malczewski · c. 1886
13. Convicts on the Way to Siberia
    Jacek Malczewski · 1890
14. In the Painter's Studio
    Leon Wyczółkowski · 1883
15. Self-Portrait in a Chinese Robe
    Leon Wyczółkowski · 1911
16. Insurgent Patrol
    Maksymilian Gierymski · 1873
17. Marshes at Sunset
    Maksymilian Gierymski · c. 1868–1869
18. Landscape with a Birch Grove
    Maksymilian Gierymski · c. 1868–1869
19. Aeneas and Dido
    Charles Alphonse Dufresnoy · 1650–1700
20. Smokers in an Inn
    Adriaen Brouwer · 1627 - 1630

01 / 20

The Battle of Grunwald

Jan Matejko

1878 · National Museum in Warsaw



Jan Matejko. Battle of Grunwald. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Weapons, banners, horses and bodies compete across the battlefield, with no easy open route between them. Matejko constructs victory through many local encounters rather than one action that explains everything. Stronger light distinguishes certain figures without clearing the surrounding congestion. The effort required to read the scene becomes part of its account of collective history.

Object source · Open artwork

02 / 20

Stańczyk during a Ball at the Court of Queen Bona

Jan Matejko

1862 · National Museum in Warsaw



Jan Matejko. Stańczyk during a Ball at the Court of Queen. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The doorway separates the brightly occupied festivities from the seated jester's clasped hands and still body. A nearby letter makes information, rather than immediate action, part of the scene. Matejko reverses the expectation attached to the red costume: the entertainer becomes the serious figure. The architecture makes his separation from the court legible before its historical implications are explained.

Object source · Open artwork

03 / 20

Equestrian Portrait of Stanisław Kostka Potocki

Jacques-Louis David

1781 · Oil on canvas · National Museum in Warsaw



Jacques-Louis David. Equestrian Portrait of Stanislas Kostka Potocki. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/jacques-louis-david/equestrian-portrait-of-stanislas-kostka-potocki-1781 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The raised hat opens the rider's gesture towards an audience, while the horse's lifted leg gives the encounter controlled energy. David makes movement serve a formal presentation of authority. The substantial stone setting helps contain that display. Horse and sitter do different work, but their coordinated poses turn the portrait into a deliberately staged arrival.

Object source · Open artwork

04 / 20

Four

Józef Chełmoński

1880 · Oil on canvas · National Museum in Warsaw



Józef Chełmoński. Four. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/jozef-chelmonski/four · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The horses spread across the low format as the carriage advances over wet ground. Chełmoński makes their legs and uneven positions articulate the team's speed, with the open sky offering little obstruction. Keep this Warsaw composition distinct from the larger related *Four-in-Hand* in Kraków. Similar subjects and translated titles do not establish that two records describe the same canvas.

Object source · Open artwork

05 / 20

Partridges in the Snow

Józef Chełmoński

1891 · National Museum in Warsaw



Józef Chełmoński. Partridges in the snow. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/jozef-chelmonski/partridges-in-the-snow · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The birds' compact bodies and scattered traces interrupt a field of snow that is otherwise nearly empty. Chełmoński lets their small scale make the exposure clear. The landscape does not need a human observer inside it to become consequential. Its faint horizon gives the flock little visual shelter, making each dark shape count against the pale expanse.

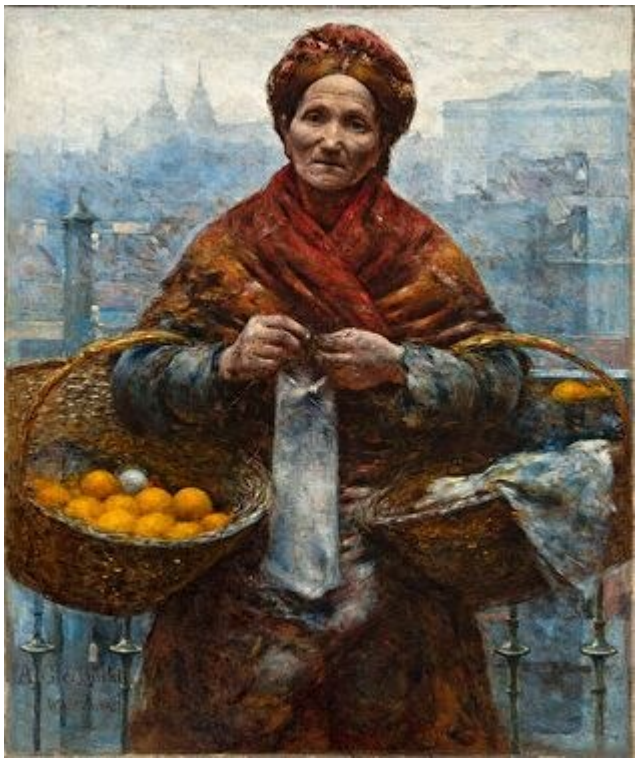
Object source · Open artwork

06 / 20

Jewish Woman with Oranges

Aleksander Gierymski

c. 1880 - 1881 · Oil on canvas · National Museum in Warsaw



Aleksander Gierymski; National Museum in Warsaw; Muzeum Narodowe w Warszawie. DOMENA PUBLICZNA (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · DOMENA PUBLICZNA

The baskets identify a livelihood, but the woman's frontal presence does not let her become a minor accessory to a street view. Gierymski gives layered clothes and face the sustained attention of portraiture. Her work remains visible without exhausting her identity. The close composition asks the viewer to meet the seller before treating the goods as an attractive still life.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: MP 5526 MNW

07 / 20

Peasant Coffin

Aleksander Gierymski

1894 · Oil on canvas · National Museum in Warsaw



Aleksander Gierymski; National Museum in Warsaw; Muzeum Narodowe w Warszawie. DOMENA PUBLICZNA (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · DOMENA PUBLICZNA

The small blue coffin interrupts an ordinary yard. Gierymski places the seated people apart, allowing stillness and separation to carry the grief instead of a conspicuous lamenting gesture. The house and resting dog keep daily surroundings present. Loss appears within a place already used for other purposes, rather than within a setting made solely for mourning.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: MP 964 MNW

08 / 20

In the Orangery

Olga Boznańska

1890 · Oil on canvas · National Museum in Warsaw



Olga Boznańska [qualified attribution: malarka; ;]; National Museum in Warsaw; Muzeum Narodowe w Warszawie. DOMENA PUBLICZNA (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · DOMENA PUBLICZNA

Tall plants surround the woman, but her restrained pose and pale clothing preserve a distinct human presence. The basket gives the hand a practical object to hold amid the cultivated display. Boznańska makes enclosure and growth share the setting. The sitter belongs among the plants without being reduced to one more decorative form.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: MP 401 MNW

09 / 20

Portrait of a Black Woman

Anna Bilińska

1884 · Oil on canvas · National Museum in Warsaw



Anna Bilińska-Bohdanowiczowa [qualified attribution: malarka; ;]; National Museum in Warsaw; Muzeum Narodowe w Warszawie. DOMENA PUBLICZNA (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · DOMENA PUBLICZNA

Pale drapery and gold jewellery frame a turned face whose gaze continues beyond the picture. Bilińska makes the pose particular even though the sitter's name is not supplied by the catalogue identification. The studio arrangement should not be mistaken for a complete account of her life. Close attention to the individual face matters precisely where the historical label remains general.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: MP 5531 MNW

10 / 20

Unfinished Self-Portrait

Anna Bilińska

1892 · Oil on canvas · National Museum in Warsaw



Anna Bilińska-Bohdanowiczowa [qualified attribution: malarka; ;]; National Museum in Warsaw; Muzeum Narodowe w Warszawie. DOMENA PUBLICZNA (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · DOMENA PUBLICZNA

The face is more fully resolved than parts of the clothing and surroundings. Bilińska's firm stance survives those unequal stages, making the portrait coherent before every surface has been completed. The exposed preparation provides evidence of construction, not merely an absence to regret. It shows how a painting can develop locally rather than becoming finished everywhere at the same rate.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: MP 261 MNW

11 / 20

Polish Hamlet: Portrait of Aleksander Wielopolski

Jacek Malczewski

1903 · Oil on canvas · National Museum in Warsaw



Jacek Malczewski; National Museum in Warsaw; Muzeum Narodowe w Warszawie. DOMENA PUBLICZNA (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · DOMENA PUBLICZNA

The central man cannot be read independently of the two contrasting women beside him. Youth and age, bright dress and restraint make their presence more than incidental setting. Malczewski gives the portrait an allegorical pressure: the figure appears caught between alternatives that the image does not reconcile. His place in the arrangement matters as much as his likeness.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: MP 369 MNW

12 / 20

Foot Washing: A Siberian Scene

Jacek Malczewski

c. 1886 · National Museum in Warsaw



Foot washing (Siberian scene). Jacek Malczewski; Source credit: National Museum in Warsaw. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame resize and JPEG compression. · Public domain

Reaching hands gather attention around a bare foot. Malczewski makes a limited act of care carry the exile subject through bodily contact rather than through a panoramic view of hardship. Selected faces and cloth emerge from the dim interior, keeping the encounter close. The task acknowledges vulnerability without requiring every participant to perform the same expression of suffering.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: MP 1198 MNW

13 / 20

Convicts on the Way to Siberia

Jacek Malczewski

1890 · National Museum in Warsaw



On the way to exile (Convicts on the way to Siberia). Jacek Malczewski; Source credit: National Museum in Warsaw. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame resize and JPEG compression. · Public domain

The title promises a journey, but the image pauses it inside a crowded room. Seated and reclining bodies give fatigue several distinct forms, while the standing figure breaks their low arrangement. Malczewski makes waiting and confinement part of movement under compulsion. The common ordeal does not erase differences in how its participants occupy the available space.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: MP 1049 MNW

14 / 20

In the Painter's Studio

Leon Wyczółkowski

1883 · National Museum in Warsaw



Leon Wyczółkowski. In the painter's studio. Image credit: Leon Wyczółkowski; Source credit: National Museum in Warsaw. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The woman stands beside a large framed picture within a room containing further images. Wyczółkowski places art among the things people encounter, rather than showing it only as the finished object now before the viewer. Her position and the furnishings make the studio a social space. Looking at a picture becomes one possible subject of another picture.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: MP 5530 MNW

15 / 20

Self-Portrait in a Chinese Robe

Leon Wyczółkowski

1911 · Pastel · National Museum in Warsaw



Leon Wyczółkowski. Self-Portrait In Chinese Tailoring. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/leon-wyczolkowski/self-portrait-in-chinese-tailoring · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Patterned robe and blue textile nearly connect figure to background through their shared activity. The face remains sufficiently distinct to hold the self-portrait's centre. Wyczółkowski makes chosen fabric part of a constructed public appearance. The costume describes a decision about representation; it should not be made to establish cultural expertise or a personal history that the image alone cannot supply.

Object source · Open artwork

16 / 20

Insurgent Patrol

Maksymilian Gierymski

1873 · Oil on canvas · National Museum in Warsaw



Maksymilian Gierymski; National Museum in Warsaw; Muzeum Narodowe w Warszawie. DOMENA PUBLICZNA (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression of the source reproduction. · DOMENA PUBLICZNA

The mounted group pauses in country with few landmarks. Its watchfulness gives the otherwise open ground a potential significance that is not yet resolved by an encounter. Maksymilian Gierymski places military action in a state of waiting. A broad pale sky and low terrain leave the figures exposed rather than enclosing them within a clearly bounded battlefield.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: MP 418 MNW

17 / 20

Marshes at Sunset

Maksymilian Gierymski

c. 1868–1869 · National Museum in Warsaw



View of marshes at sunset. Maksymilian Gierymski; Source credit: National Museum in Warsaw. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame resize and JPEG compression. · Public domain

Pools and dark grasses provide uneven passages through the foreground, while a narrow strip of distant light supplies the main opening. Gierymski allows weather to organise the scene's visibility. The low horizon gives the clouds considerable authority over the view. There is no dominant building or traveller to turn the marsh into a setting for another subject.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: MP 1366 MNW

18 / 20

Landscape with a Birch Grove

Maksymilian Gierymski

c. 1868–1869 · National Museum in Warsaw



Landscape with a birch grove. Maksymilian Gierymski; Source credit: National Museum in Warsaw. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Full-frame resize and JPEG compression. · Public domain

The sandy track curves past slender trees and makes the landscape traversable without introducing a traveller. Pale ground and small vegetation marks keep the near terrain specific. Gierymski finds sufficient structure in the relation between a route, a grove and open fields. The absence of an event lets these ordinary intervals remain the reason for looking.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: MP 1367 MNW

19 / 20

Aeneas and Dido

Charles Alphonse Dufresnoy

1650–1700 · National Museum in Warsaw



Charles Alphonse du Fresnoy. Aeneas and Dido.. Image credit: Attributed to Charles Alphonse du Fresnoy. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Robes of distinct colours help separate the figures gathered around the seated woman. Dufresnoy gives the literary encounter a ceremonial setting, but gestures preserve an exchange among individuals inside that order. Attendants and vessels expand the occasion without dissolving its centre. The scene is crowded yet organised to remain more readily readable than a battlefield.

Object source · Open artwork

20 / 20

Smokers in an Inn

Adriaen Brouwer

1627 - 1630 · Oil on copper · National Museum in Warsaw



Adriaen Brouwer. Smokers in an Inn. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/adriaen-brouwer/smokers-in-an-inn · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

One man raises a pipe while others occupy the small table in unequal poses. Brouwer allows attention to settle on absorbed, informal actions rather than a coordinated public presentation. Warm light recovers clothing from the dark room without making every detail equally clear. Sociability is represented as people doing things together, with no requirement that they pose as a harmonious group.

Object source · Open artwork

Leave some questions open

Compare the foreground seller or mourner with a named historical protagonist: what changes in scale, gesture and surroundings? A picture can establish circumstances without explaining an entire person. Check the museum's current programme and individual display information; this collection selection is not a guaranteed route through the galleries.

Further reading

The Practice and Science of Drawing

Harold Speed · Read free · English

Speed’s discussion of mass, line and portrait construction supplies practical vocabulary for the very different faces and crowded scenes in this guide. His preferences belong to his own period; use the exercises as prompts for looking.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12

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